College Bound

ISSUES & TRENDS FOR THE COLLEGE ADMISSIONS ADVISOR

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Admissions Watch

Classes Filling EA/ED. According to VPM.org, Virginia's home for public media, early rounds of admissions for Fall 2026 show many selective universities again filling 40 to 60 percent of their freshman class through ED/EA. Several institutions posted double-digit increases in early applications including Boston C., 15 percent; Emory U., 21 percent; Northwestern U., 15 percent and U. of Virginia, 11 percent. National coverage ties part of the surge to lingering test-optional policies at many schools. Where requirements resumed, some campuses reported lower early volume.

Bowdoin Admitted 13 Percent Early. Bowdoin C. in Maine received 14,694 total applications for its Class of 2030, 5 percent more than last year and the most in school history. Bowden received 2,301 applications across its two Early Decision rounds, from which 301 students were offered admissions, about 13.1 percent. Another 28 students were admitted through the QuestBridge National College Match, senior vice president Claudia Marroquin told the *Orient*.

Johns Hopkings 813 ED Admits. Johns Hopkins U. in Baltimore welcomed its first 813 students to the Class of 2030 through its Early Decision I and II, according to the *News-Letter*.

Michigan Record. The U. of Michigan–Ann Arbor set a new record with 115,125 total undergraduate applications, including 108,666 first-year applications for Fall 2025, a 29 percent increase over the past five years.

UM now offers both Early Decision and Early Action. Full Fall 2026 enrollment data will be released in October 2026.

Swarthmore's ED. Swarthmore C., outside Philadelphia, received 1,249 applications for its Class of 2030 through ED I and II, Jim Bock, vice president and dean of admissions, told *The Phoenix,* about 32 fewer than last year. Swarthmore accepted 231 of them or 18.5 percent.

Swarthmore is continuing its test-optional policy for five more years. Bock told the paper that the school had seen "non-worrisome differences in GPA data between current students who submitted scores and those who didn't." Only 43 percent of applicants this cycle took advantage of the option and chose not to submit either the SAT or ACT.

Swarthmore also adopted rules prohibiting applicants from using AI to draft essays, nor does Swarthmore use AI in its decision-making process.

USC Still Deciding. The U. of Southern California in Los Angeles admitted 9.5 percent of its Early Action applicants, the highest number in the last three years, according to the *Daily Trojan*. USC expects to admit an additional 5,000 students during its Regular Decision cycle and will release those results by April 1.

Going forward, USC students who apply Early Decision for next year must submit their applications by November 1 and will not be permitted to apply to other institutions. Those decisions will be released in mid-December, roughly one month before Early Action decisions.

Vanderbilt Admits 11.9 Percent ED. Vanderbilt U. in Tennessee received 7,727 applications for its Early Decision I and II programs and admitted 11.9 percent of them to its Class of 2030.

Virginia Offers Largest Portion of New Class Through Early Action. The U. of Virginia received 57,500 applications and admitted 7,151 students to its class of 2030 through its first three rounds of early pro-

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Financial Matters

Gifts Plummet 9.2 Percent. Gifts to college endowments plummeted by 9.2 percent in fiscal year 2025. However, giving to colleges still totaled almost $14 billion, according to the National Association of College and University Business Officers.

Additionally, annual investment returns on U.S. college endowments grew by 10.9 percent, down from 11.2 percent the previous year. The total worth of U.S. college and university endowments now stands at about $944.3 billion, up from $873.7 billion last year.

Harvard owns the largest endowment at $55.7 billion, followed by Yale U.'s $44.1 billion, Stanford U's $40.8 billion, Princeton U.'s $36.4 billion, MIT's $27.4 billion, U. of Texas System's $27.2 billion, U. of Pennsylvania's $24.8 billion, Texas A&M U. System's $22.2 billion, U. of Michigan's $21.2 billion and U. of California's $20.1 billion.

On the downside, to cover uncertain federal funding, colleges withdrew $33.4 billion in 2025, up 11 percent from the previous year, according to a National Association of College and University Business Officers-Commonfund survey (NACUBO).

Pell Grant Shortfall? The Congressional Budget Office projections for fiscal year 2027 indicate an annual Pell Grant shortfall of $11.5 billion, and a cumulative shortfall of $132 billion. According to the National Association of Student Financial Aid Administrators (NASFAA), "The Pell Grant program is uniquely funded in that it relies on both mandatory (set in the Higher Education Act) and discretionary (subject to Congress' annual

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Financial Matters

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appropriations) funding streams. "This CBO report comes after Congress repeatedly, for four consecutive years, decided to flat fund the Pell Grant program."

Karen McCarthy, NASFAA vice president, said, "Separate the argument about college costs and how fast they're increasing. We're not even keeping up with the base level of inflation over the last four years."

More appropriations, beyond the $10.5 billion Congress recently appropriated in the "One Big Beautiful Bill," will be required to fully fund student need. Currently, 7.6 million students receive Pell Grants. Some 1.7 million more students were eligible for maximum Pell Grants in 2025-26, according to the National College Attainment Network.

Defaults Up. "Millions of student loan borrowers aren't repaying their loans and defaults are up," reported National Public Radio (NPR). Nearly one million borrowers defaulted on their federal student loans and student loan delinquencies have worsened, according to the latest Household Debt and Credit Report from the Federal Reserve Bank of New York. Nearly 10 percent of student loan balances are more than 90 days past due.

One surprising aspect of the report was that borrowers over the age of 50 were more likely than any other group to have loans transitioning into "serious delinquency."

Another consequence is that "nearly one third (32 percent) of those currently paying off student loans have delayed purchasing a home due to their debt, and the percentage is even higher among Gen. Z and Millennial borrowers, 37 percent and 36 percent, respectively."

Full Fare? A study by the Brookings Institution found that only 16 percent of students enrolled in private nonprofit institutions paid the advertised price for tuition. Meanwhile, 26 percent of in-state students at public colleges paid the sticker price, according to *Cardinal News*.

State Support for Higher Education "Softens." According to the State Higher Education Executive Officers Association (SHEEO), support for higher education in the fiscal year 2026 reached $133.1 billion, a 1 percent increase over last year. Thirty-three states reported increases in support ranging from 12.1 percent in Montana to 0.1 percent in Florida. But 12 states and Washington DC reported decreases in state support ranging from -13.6 percent in Arizona to -1.6 percent in North Carolina.

ENROLLMENT TRENDS

National Enrollment Overview. Industry interviews this year describe a 1 percent year-over-year national enrollment uptick masking wide campus-level variance, with many schools cutting low-enrollment programs (especially in humanities) while expanding short-term credentials/online programs, according to fsapartners.ed.gov. (FSA Partner Connect is for individuals involved in the administration of Title IV financial aid.)

Post-Supreme Court AA Ruling Enrollment at 3,000 Institutions. Class Action, a nonprofit organization founded in Massachusetts in 2004 and dedicated to "ending classism and addressing issues of social class, inequality, and cross-class understanding," released a new report, "The Future of Fair Admissions: A First Look at College Enrollment Outcomes After the End of Affirmative Action."

It compares first-time enrollments in 2022 and 2023 to enrollments in 2024 in over 3,000 colleges and universities for more than 3,000,000 freshmen. Among its findings:

- "Both the number and the percentage of underrepresented students of color significantly declined at highly-selective institutions and even more at Ivy Plus schools."
- But "The number and share of underrepresented students of color increased almost everywhere else, most notably at state flagship universities. For example, Black freshman enrollment increased by 30 percent at LSU and 50 percent at the University of Mississippi, while Hispanic enrollment increased more than one third at the University of Tennessee and the University of South Carolina."

Class Action has created the Post-SFFA Enrollment Dashboard on its website at www.classism.org. It allows you to "compare enrollments by race and gender over time at more than 3,000 institutions and in hundreds of different groupings."

State News

North Carolina's Gender Imbalance. According to a new report, women's undergraduate enrollment in North Carolina has grown at nearly twice the pace of men's from 1980 to 2023. "The men that are going to college are not going into professions where they are sorely needed," said Chris Marsicano. He added that boys are falling behind from the very start of their school experience.

SUNY Reports Three Straight Years of Growth. The State University of New York (SUNY) has experienced three continuous years of student growth and stable budgets, according to Chancellor John B. King, Jr. He predicted that the system would close a projected $1 billion budget gap within a decade. However, the state's main student financial aid program, TAP, is losing purchasing power. The average wage increased 21 percent since 2008, while inflation rose 44 percent. Tuition at SUNY and the City University of New York has grown over three times faster than the average award.

Texas Dallas Still Lost Millions in Foreign Student Tuition & Fees. Like most American universities, the impact of visa disruptions and denials has had a major impact upon school budgets and caused significant problems, leading to program cutbacks and loss of staff.

For example, the U. of Texas Dallas enrolled 5,603 foreign students in Fall 2024. But in Fall 2025, that number fell to 4,298, a drop of 1,305 students or about 23 percent of the overseas student population. That translated into $55,437,371 in tuition and fees in Fall 2025, down from $268,222,448 in Fall 2024.

More than half of UTD's graduate population, about 55 percent, consisted of foreign nationals. The majority of the foreign student population came from India. ■

Local News

Emory & Henry U. Resets Tuition. Emory & Henry U., a private university in Emory, Virginia, founded in 1836 and historically affiliated with the United Methodist Church, announced that it is resetting its tuition for Fall 2026 from roughly $40,000 to under $20,000. Undergraduate housing costs about $6,000 to $10,000 per year and the meal plan adds another $6,000 to $7,000 annually for residential students. E&H enrolls 1,100 undergraduates and about 230 graduate students.

Fraud Exposed. Officials at Jefferson C. in Hillsboro, Missouri, south of St. Louis said they flagged more than 1,500 applicants for potential fraud. "The main goal of these 'ghost students' is to receive financial aid," Harvey-Manus, the college's vice president of student services, told *The Leader*. He added that this is a national problem.

The potentially fraudulent applications were submitted for the Spring 2025, Summer 2025, Fall 2025, Spring 2026, Summer 2026 and Fall 2026 semesters "If a suspected fraudulent applicant applied for federal financial aid, we would report it to the Dept. of Ed.'s Office of Inspector General," he said.

Georgetown to Boost Tuition by 4.7 Percent. Georgetown U. announced that undergraduate tuition for the 2026-27 school year will increase by 4.75 percent to $74,520. Georgetown also expects to award a record $278 million in financial aid to undergraduate and graduate students in the upcoming academic year. ■

The Counselor's Corner

Inside Admissions Offices

Alabama Preps H.S. Students. The U. of Alabama launched an effort to help prepare the state's high school students for college. Tide to Success is a six-hour, self-paced, online course structured around test preparation designed to help students build the skills, strategies and confidence needed to succeed on standardized tests.

"The University of Alabama has a responsibility to help Alabama's high school students in their pursuit of an education," said UA president Peter J. Mohler.

Albany's Direct Admissions. Select students from the Albany, New York, school system who post a 90 GPA and have completed advanced math are now automatically admitted to the U. of Albany. About 80 students have already been accepted, according to ABC News 10.

Houston's Direct Admissions. Houston Independent School District seniors with 2.5 GPAs or above are opening acceptance letters from the U. of Houston-Downtown without even having to apply, thanks to its new direct admissions program. "HIDS and UHD share the belief that Houston's future is in Houston," Christine Hole, HISD Chief Academic Officer, said. She added that about 7,700 students qualify for the offer but will have to complete an application.

Perspectives on Process

Brown's Admissions Process. Reporters at the *Brown Daily Herald* wanted to know more about how its admissions office works, so it sent out two reporters to find out. Here is what they reported.

"There is never just one person who decides the final yes or no on an application. Generally, applications are read by an officer who specializes in the geographic region that the applicant is from before the candidate is discussed by a broader admissions committee. Conversations among the broader group tend to be longer for students they are considering admitting.…"

"Admissions officers also look for students who are engaged with their communities and will get involved with the Brown community in a variety of disciplines, from performing arts to athletics to comedy.…

Other Considerations. "Another key aspect the admissions committee considers is how prospective students will fit in with Brown's Open Curriculum and excel with 'flexibility and choice.…'

"The admissions committee does not use artificial intelligence to sort through any of the applications, no matter a student's academic standing… I think that surprises a lot of people when we say that we are reading every single page of every application that comes to us.…"

"The supplement [questions] speaks to the University's 'human-centered approach to admissions,' complementing the first question that focuses more on academics.…

"There is no difference in the review process for Early Decision and Regular Decision applications, aside from knowing that Brown is the number one choice of students who apply early. The expectations of an applicant being a 'good community member' and a successful student at Brown do not change."

When an application is deferred, the office is "never doing it simply to postpone a decision… [they are] doing it because these are very competitive and compelling candidates that we simply want to look at again, within our broader pool in Regular Decision… Brown ends up admitting a 'sizable amount' of deferred applicants."

Harvard Professor Criticizes Elite Admissions. Harvard government professor Michael J. Sandel criticized selective college admissions as a source of inequality and social division at an event at the Harvard Graduate School of Education, according to the *Harvard Crimson*.

Sandel argued that elite universities have helped recast inherited advantage as earned success. He said admissions at highly-selective colleges shapes how Americans understand success and failure, it convinces those who gain entry that they deserve their outcomes, and those who do not that they have only themselves to blame.

"The divide between winners and losers has been deepened, poisoning our politics, setting us apart," he said. Sandel challenged the assumption that meritocratic competition offers equal opportunity, citing international data on social mobility. In Denmark, he said, it takes roughly two generations for someone born into poverty to reach the median income. In the United States, it takes five—a disparity he said reflects deeply unequal starting points.…

Disparities Linger. "Sandel also criticized the central role of four-year college degrees in determining economic security, noting that roughly 62 percent of Americans do not hold one. He argued that universities—particularly elite institutions—have reinforced this hierarchy by prioritizing selectivity.

"We allowed ourselves in fulfilling this role—this meritocratic mission—to become sorting machines for a market-driven, meritocratic society," he said. Selective admissions, Sandel argued, "advantages students whose parents attended elite colleges, compounding benefits such as access to strong schools, test preparation and extracurricular opportunities.

"The reason for the strenuous striving is that the transition privilege of meritocratic privilege is not guaranteed," he said. "It depends on getting in."

"As a remedy, Sandel proposed introducing lottery systems at highly selective institutions once applicants meet a basic threshold of qualification. Sandel finished by calling for expanding access to high-level learning beyond elite campuses and using technology to make education 'a public good, not just a private privilege.'

"What we really need is to break down the steep hierarchy of prestige that has come to inform this sort of intuition," he said. "Promoting teaching and learning, especially on civic questions, should not be the sole province of the young people who win admission to selective universities." ■

COUNSELOR'S BOOKSHELF

Peak Higher Ed: How to Survive the Coming Academic Crisis by Bryan Alexander; argues higher ed faces a critical turning point; 216 pages; Johns Hopkins University; $36.95 hardcover; ISBN-13-978-1421454702.

Reinventing the Post-Admission Playbook: New strategies for the final stages of student recruitment by Eric Hoover; 58 pages, digital file size, 16.5 MB; $199. Available at the Chronicle bookstore. Focuses on how colleges can enroll more accepted students.

The Budget Crisis Is Here: How smart institutions are responding; from the Chronicle of Higher Education, 50 pages, digital; $199.

Includes results from its survey of 275 higher education employees who work with budgets or finances. ■

CURRICULUM CAPSULES

Baylor Adds Biomedical Engineering. Baylor U. in Texas announced a new Bachelor of Science in Biomedical Engineering within its School of Engineering and Computer Science. The degree builds on an existing biomedical emphasis within mechanical engineering but will now allow students to specialize more directly in the field. "Biomedical Engineering is a high-growth field that combines engineering and health care, while opening doors to research partnerships." Also, Baylor's four-year graduation rate hit 77.3 percent for the cohort entering in Fall 2021. "Graduation rates are one of the most important levers to help increase affordability," Linda Livinston, president of the Board of Regents, told the *Baylor Lariat*. "The quicker students can progress towards their degree, the less they have to pay."

Texas San Antonio Eliminates Race and Gender Studies. The U. of Texas San Antonio shuttered its Department of Race, Ethnicity, Gender and Sexuality Studies that launched in 2020, according to the *San Antonio Express-News*. The department included African American and Mexican American studies. These will be combined with the Department of Bicultural-Bilingual Studies. "Consolidation, elimination and censorship of academic programs that focus on those topics have already been happening at other public universities in Texas," the paper said.

Virginia's Career Design Initiative. The U. of Virginia is integrating a Career Design and Discovery Initiative into the curriculum of every undergraduate Arts and Sciences major to help graduates prepare for post-college life. UVA will seek to bring advising and experiential learning to all students. The program will begin with first-year students and expand beyond them.

Washington U's New Pharmacy School and Biochemistry Major. Washington U. in St. Louis announced that it will absorb the 162-year-old UHSP, the first College of Pharmacy west of the Mississippi River, into its new College of Pharmacy. WashU's 10th college will begin operation in Spring 2027.

"Beyond its academic impact, the combination represents an investment in St. Louis and the broader region—strengthening the future of pharmacy education, supporting jobs and economic activity and reinforcing Saint Louis's role as a national center for bioscience innovation," the university wrote in a statement.

WashU also announced a new biochemistry major for Fall 2026. The new major retains traditional foundations of introductory biology, chemistry, physics and calculus, but restructures the core curriculum. "A very high portion of research at the interface of chemistry and biology relies on large datasets. Students need training and statistics and data analysis to handle this effectively," said Jennifer Heemstra, chairman of the chemistry department. ■

SCHOLARSHIP SCOOPS

Grinnell Offers $50,000 for Iowa Students with Weighted 4.0 GPA. The Iowa Dean's Scholarship is designed to attract more top students and is renewable for eight semesters. It joins Grinnell's Iowa Access Initiative which awards scholarships to students from families earning less than $100,000.

Dreams Scholarships. The state of Georgia will begin awarding about $325 million in "Dreams" scholarships funded by the state lottery. The lottery currently funds HOPE Scholarships and Pre-K ed. About $25 million will be available for Fall 2026 students.

The rest will go into a long-term endowment. Dreams scholarships will be last dollar funding for qualified Georgia residents who have "unmet financial needs." ■

NEWS YOU CAN USE

Graduate Salaries to Increase. A new survey by the National Association of Colleges and Employers of 150 employers suggests that the starting salaries for graduates of the Class of 2026 will increase for almost every major.

Physical scientists such as physicists, chemists, material scientists and geologists can expect a 10.2 percent increase in salary to about $82,766. Computer science hires may see a 6.9 percent increase from $76,251 last year to $81,535 this year, while engineering majors may score a 3.1 percent salary increase from last year. Only graduates in the social sciences are expected to see a decrease in base pay, from $67,316 to $66,155.

AI's Impact. Many college students are experimenting with AI on their own. But, about 56 percent of college students are required to use AI in coursework, mostly for brainstorming, editing, explaining various concepts, according to a survey by Honorlock, an online proctoring service based in Florida. But only 20 percent are taking AI courses in their colleges to learn about its full potential, such as data analysis, marketing, coding or cyber security. However, that is likely to change as the pace of artificial intelligence is more rapidly integrated into all aspects of society.

Writing in *FUTURISM*, Joe Wilkins asserts, "As AI appears to do much of the work of entry-level job seekers, the entire premise of a college education seems to be collapsing."

Of course, that is short-sighted since college does much more than simply train students for entry level positions. Universities are involved in advanced level research as well as putting it all into perspective via the humanities. But AI offers alternative learning routes.

Ryan Craig author of *Apprentice Nation* told the *New York Times Magazine* that colleges "need to figure out how to integrate relevant, in-field, and hopefully paid work experience for every student, and hopefully multiply experiences before they graduate."

Meanwhile, a survey by the consulting firm EAB indicates that 46 percent of high school students are using AI in their college search process. Some 62 percent say they are using it as a tool to find colleges that are a good fit for them, while 34 percent say their interest in an institution grew because of AI research. About 18 percent said they eliminated colleges because of what AI said. Some 50 percent use it to research application requirements and only 25 percent use it to create application materials.

At the same time, a majority said they would react negatively if they suspected communication from a college was AI-generated. ■

ADMISSIONS WATCH

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grams. About 13,500 of the applicants were from Virginia and 3,071 of them were admitted. More than 44,000 out-of-state students applied and 4,080 of them were admitted.

About 8,480 students were deferred to UVA's 3rd and final admission cycle of Regular Decision and they will be notified by April 1. Overall, more than 82,000 students applied to join UVA's new class, 27 percent more than last year's record high, according to Greg Roberts, dean of admission. ■

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